



Ashes at Closing Time

by
Cohen Benjamin

(as ghostwritten by Quinn Tyler Jackson)

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littera manet sed lector oraculum
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Meaning arises through
engagement, not endorsement.

A stylized, handwritten signature in black ink that reads "Quinn Tyler Jackson".

The *Malocchio*

—It hurts, Sandra. Damn it.

—Yeah, well, stop, then.

She gets a Caesar together and shoves it down my way.

—Caesar? Spicy. It *hurts*, damn it.

She puts her hands on her hips, does the nose in the air thing, and says —Well, well, who knows what's *what* around here?

Damn. Goes down burning. Few seconds later, it doesn't hurt so bad. —I'll be damned.

—Trust me. Got to learn to trust me.

Couple of minutes later, I can feel the vodka running circles in my blood. Maybe that's Sandra dancing down my veins. All the same.

—You're the alchemist, I concede.

—*Abacadabra!*

—Poof! I wiggle my fingers around like I'm up in smoke.

—You've *got* to stop. Looks up, rubbing a glass clean with a towel.

I light up, do a Bogart sneer, and tell her to mind her own business. This place is noisy. Too damned noisy at lunch.

—Could be can...

—Yeah, well, screw you. Always wanted to say that. Felt good.

Let's try it again. Play it again, Sam. OK, OK, Bogart never actually said *that*.

—Watch your language, she says. She's smiling all over so she doesn't mean it any more than I meant mine. She knows I mean no wrong by her.

I lean over the Caesar. Ash falls in.

—You can't drink *that*.

—Not part of the potion?

She reaches for it, but before she can get it, I put it back and it's gone.

—Gross!

Just ash. Nothing major. Isn't going to kill me. Wave, wave. —
Make me another, will you?

Yeah, yeah, I know. Too much these days. Too much excess causes a defect, too many defects cause an excess.

—No such thing as *too little* excess, now, is there.

She just keeps smiling at me, like she's not hearing what I'm saying. Can't ever piss her off. Ask her why.

—You're kid's stuff, she explains.

Guy beside me doesn't seem to get it. Keeps giving me the *malocchio*. What's it to him?

—Buddy, didn't your mother ever tell you not to stare?

Gets all flustered, looks away, then looks back. — Didn't yours ever tell you not to swear at a *lady*?

I get up, makes the shirt nervous. Feels like I'm going to tip over, but it doesn't feel like the drink doing it. Vertigo again. Damn. Get behind me, Satan.

He's dressed in executive-style clothing. Probably figures I'm going to mess his tie up or something, so he won't be able to do the boardroom ballet when he gets back to the box. I want to throw my drink in his face but decide against wasting what's left of it.

—Take it easy, I say. Then I turn to Sandra and bow.

—If the lady will beg my pardon. It seems I'm in the presence of a *gentleman*.

Sandra is laughing to beat all hell. Guy's really uneasy now. I sit down and put back half my second Caesar. Sandra walks over to him and whispers something into his ear with a big grin.

Damn it hurts. —Hey, Sandra. The Caesar's not working anymore. Double vodka neat? Why'd that come out sounding like question ... I'm paying, aren't I?

It comes, I put it back. There. Gone now. What the hell *is* that?

Shouldn't hurt like *that*.

—1976, I say.

—What?

—The song. 1976.

—Get out!

I look over at the executive and give him the Tell Her I Mean It look.

—Yes, he finally says. 1976. Big in 1977, though. The shirt has a clue.

—Way before my time. I'm *Pet Shop Boys*, not *Eagles*.

Come Here. Yeah, over here. That's what it means when someone wags his finger like that. Closer. OK, listen.

—When's your shift over?

—Half an hour. Why? Well, not over yet ... just my break.

I don't know. I just like asking stupid questions. What the hell do you think?

—I want to buy you a new blouse, I say. Yes, it sounds stupid, I know. Stupid as all get go, but I saw one there that would really suit her.

She smiles, stands in that hands on hips thing again, and wags her head the Big Bad No. Then comes the Naughty-Naughty finger shake, to my Come Here wag.

It's a duel now. Come Here again. Naughty-Naughty. A few rounds, back, around and forth, and then, yeah, she's got it.

—C'mon. The place down the street. I saw a nice one. Made just for you.

She blushes. Works *here* and I made her blush. I light up another, looking over at the staring executive. —Was that a good year for you?

—Pardon?

—1976.

—I don't know. I just know the song. Famous enough.

Oh, Jumping Jesus. Right. He *is* young looking. Upwardly futile. That must be what hurts so damned bad. I'm old now. Jump the cigarette's cherry up near my nose like a clown might smoke it and screw my eyes crossed. Guy looks away.

Yeah, well, I could do “suit” in my day. I was probably the guy who hired the guy who hired you.

Look back at Sandra, do the same stupid trick, and she laughs so hard it makes her breasts shake. Would look nice in that blouse, or out of it. Come Here. Same finger wag thing.

—I can’t go out with you.

Bring your alibis.

Screw that. Give me another double neat. I’ve already gotten over *that*.

—You driving?

No. Walking to a taxi. I can’t feel my feet.

Drink comes soon enough and kills a bit more of that damned—what the *hell* is that?—that damned thing in there. Down, up, and out, without so much as a goodbye to Sandra or the shirt.

Fresh air hurts. Still can’t feel my feet. Fresh air usually brings them back. There we go. They’re back. Halfway down the block, change my mind and go back to the bar.

—Just a blouse, Sandra, for crying out loud. A *blouse*. Finally. Got past the bullshit. She smiles, nods OK, and I sit down again. Guy in the stuffed shirt gets up, pays his bill, and heads off. Good riddance. Another one just like him takes his place. They never end.

Half hour comes due, she goes back, Mike takes her place, and I’m out the door, waiting for her. She gets there in five; I’m watching the time. I offer my arm and we start for the store where I saw the blouse.

—I don’t usually....

Yeah, yeah, I know. Neither do I, but you were looking too good to not at least try, Sandra.

—It’s not...

—Don’t sweat it, I say. I light one up and offer it to her.

—Aren’t you a gentleman?

—There it is, I say, pointing.

Nice blouse. Pale blue. A bit revealing, but it’s not something she’d be wearing at work anyway. She smiles. After she’s had the smoke, we go in, and she tries it on. Looks great. Just how I pictured her in it. I want her to wear it out, as we leave, and she puts her other one in the

bag. Feels good to have her on my arm.

—Where now? she asks, looking over at me.

Is that a line? I haven't heard a line for so long I forget what they sound like. *Where now?* What's the answer to that? She has the blouse on. Should have thought about *that* sooner. Dig around upstairs for a while, come up with nothing particularly witty sounding. With another of my smokes in her mouth, with that blouse, with the fresh air, I feel like maybe I could do one over on that young stuffed shirt from the bar.

—How about down there? I say, pointing to another row of stores. Hell, I have money. I can treat her if she wants to go *that* way.

—How about there? she says, pointing in another direction, away from stores, and near some benches. Ah, she wants to *talk*. OK. I can *talk*.

We march over to a bench, sit, and she crosses her legs like a lady. We talk about this and that for a long time, like it matters. Feels good. Almost better than the two double neats. No, definitely better than those. She laughs like a lady, too. Feels good to make a *lady* laugh.

—When do you have to go back to work? I ask.

She looks at her watch. It's been forty-five minutes. She has fifteen more. What the hell to do in fifteen minutes that *means* anything? I want it to *mean* something, damn it. The last three quarters of an hour did. Why not the next fifteen minutes? But nothing comes to mind, so I lean over to her and kiss her on the left cheek. She doesn't pull away. That *means* something. Well, it did when I was the stuffed shirt's age, hiring his boss.

God, she has nice eyes. I've noticed them before, but not out in the light of day. She puts her hand on mine, holds it. That *means* something. I can feel myself again. That *means* something. The vodka's out of me now. Just the smoke in there. I feel good. I put my other hand over hers, and she doesn't pull it away or do anything else that would make me think the moment stopped meaning something to her.

Don't go and say something stupid now, Sandra. That would really piss me off. Just sit there, smiling at me with those eyes, holding my hand. We've got just ten more minutes. I can take it. Just don't say

anything stupid, OK?

Maybe she can read my mind. We sit there, just looking at one another, holding hands like two kids. The blouse looks great on her. She'll have to change back into the other one to work again, but that doesn't matter; she's wearing this one now.

Maybe I should say something stupid. Maybe I should make it all meaningless and crack a wise one. Break the mood. This is too good. No, can't think of anything stupid to say. Five more minutes of this and I'll be OK.

Then it's time for her to go back. She walks back to the bar, but looks over her shoulder a few times at me, and finally, just before she's out of view, blows me a wet kiss.

I lean back on the bench, suck in some fresh air, and light up another cigarette. Nothing to do. That damned pain is gone for now.

It was. Had to think about it. Came back. Damn. Damn it hurts, Sandra. Cuts through me.

Go back there? No. Good things don't happen in pairs. Something shitty and dark and awful always has to come in between. Get up, wander around the street I'd pointed to first. Nothing much to see. Finally, see something worth taking a better look at, throw down my butt, rub it out under my shoe, and go in.

Nods. The usual stuff that happens when you go into a store. Smile. Point. Yeah, that.

—You know your cameras.

Of course I do. Give me that one. Card's through in no time, and I'm out. I know my cameras? Stupid ass. I walk back to the bench, put the film in, and have the roll finished faster than even young shirt would have imagined. That's a special bench. Put in another roll and sit down. A couple holding hands walks by, so I finish half a roll on them. So fast they don't even notice me shooting. I've still got it.

Then it comes back. Put the camera down. Thing's new, don't want to drop it. Vertigo. Damn. Look left, look right. Worse on the left side. Damn. Get behind me, Satan. On my feet. Stuff around the edges moves around like I'm on a horse at a fair. God, when was that last time I was on a horse at a fair? What made me think it was like

that?

—It'll pass.

—Like hell it will.

—It'll pass. Guaranteed.

—When I do.

Who the *hell* am I talking to? I look around. Oh, shit.

—Go away.

—I gave you what you *wanted*.

—Right. Sure. I held her hand, for Christ's sake. Give me a break.

—But you felt *better* for a while.

—For a *while*. I just held her hand.

—You kissed her cheek.

I just keep walking and forget about him. Back at the bar. Go in. Stuffed shirt hour is mostly up. Just the losers and boozers of the hard core now.

—Hey, Mike. Where's Sandra?

She walks out, in the old blouse, and smiles at me again. She's serving now. I pull out the camera and finish the roll on her smile before she can protest. Hands waving around like she doesn't want me to capture her soul on film or something. Too bad I didn't have this thing with me when she had the other blouse on. Or off.

She's smiling again. Nothing stopped meaning something. Good. The smile isn't the same anymore. It's better than before.

Spinning again. Damned vertigo. I close my eyes, but it doesn't go away. Worse on the left.

He's sitting over in the back of the bar. Loser or boozier, I'm not sure which. I point him out to Sandra.

—Tell Mike to kick *him* out. Big point on the "*him*."

She looks at me funny but keeps smiling. Then she walks over to Mike and tells him to kick that asshole out of the bar. Mike doesn't want to mess with him, at first, but I keep waving my hands at the guy in the corner, and Mike knows I'm a regular, so he goes over and asks Satan to leave.

Doesn't want to.

—Says he has just as much right to be here as the next guy.

I give Mike the Come Here finger. He does.

—Make me a very salty Caesar.

—How salty?

—Piss in the damned thing for all I care.

—That salty, eh? Yes, yes, already.

He makes the drink and salts it up. I take a sip to make sure. Yeah, burns like hell. I walk over to Satan, and smile. —I just held her hand, asshole.

He starts to say something, so I throw the drink in his face.

Ever see Satan get a salty drink in the eyes? He starts howling like the demon he is, throws the table like there's going to be a showdown. He's *really* pissed at me now. His eyes, all green and red and who the hell knows what that other color is. Makes me want to take a few shots, so I load the camera again.

—Put that away!

—Says you, I say as I finish loading. I have ten shots of him before he has time to get his bearings. I tap the camera. —Your soul is mine, now.

Ever see him *really* pissed?

About six guys in stuffed shirts come in the door of the bar. Their eyes are green and red and whatever the hell that other color is. Mike's eyes are bulging out at me and he looks like he's going to have a heart attack. Sandra is still just smiling that smile. Nothing is going to make it mean *nothing*.

The guys in the suits start walking towards me like the zombies they are. Oh, right, like I'm going to give them Satan's soul back. Screw that. I rip out the film and expose it to the lights. He's *screwed* now.

—Asshole, he says.

Like I give a damn. The clones are looking left and right now like they don't know what to do next. Just totally out of it. I go over to the bar, look at Sandra, and say, —How about tomorrow?

She smiles at me, puts a double neat my way, and I just know that her smile means *sure*. Nothing is going to ruin it. Not even that damned evil eye.

The Suit

I find a taxi, get to my office: the Box. Deborah is at her desk, phone headset on. Looks up at me as I come in.

—It's half-past three, she says.

—So?

She has the angry snarl. Well, not really. Halfway there, though. Half-past happy, moving towards the angry snarl.

—You missed Cranston at two.

I put my hands in my pockets, kick the ground with the Shucks, and grin. Cranston. Who cares?

—It was impor...

—Yes, indeed. It was.

Show her the camera I bought. She screws her eyes at me like I've been wasting my time on child's play, so I go down the hall into my office. Sit in my chair, staring at the new camera. Pull the four rolls of film out of my pocket that I shot that afternoon. It feels good. The shots of Sandra are the ones I want to see most. After about ten minutes of this, I pick up the phone and hit Deborah's extension.

—Could you come into my office, please?

She's there in about a minute. The rolls are on my desk, beside the camera. She still has that screwed up eye look. Gets worse when she sees the film. I take out a paper and write down my measurements. I put the film rolls on top of the paper, push the paper across the desk, and say, —I need a suit to these measurements. And could you have this developed? By tomorrow morning?

She stares up at the ceiling like I just asked her to find me a

skyhook or the Holy Grail.

—Take the rest of today off, afterwards, I offer. She's still looking at the ceiling.

Finally, she gets around to looking at the paper. —Any particular color?

—Whatever you think would flatter me, I say.

She gives me the once over, as if she has to think. —I've never seen you in a suit, Mr. York. How would I know?

—Intuition. Make something up.

Right. Nobody around here has seen me in a suit. I'm business casual. Stuffed shirts. Hate them. But Deborah is always spot on with the clothes. Always. —And pick out a nice silk tie or two that match, as well.

—Have you been drinking?

I lean back, hands folded over my chest, flipping my fingers. What kind of question is that to be asking? If I had a drink in my hand I'd throw it in her face. No, she's not a bad person. Just annoying sometimes.

—Something on your mind, Deborah?

She looks left, then right. I can tell she's holding back The Lecture no employee should give a boss.

—It's nothing, she says. She takes the paper and the film and leaves without closing the door.

I get up, nearly tipping over from vertigo. Damn. Get out of my head. Close the door, return to my desk, and dig through my pocket for the key. A few seconds later, the flask is in my hand and the vodka down me.

After the vodka has gotten inside where it belongs, down where the pain won't stop, I pick up the phone and dial her extension again. —You can take tomorrow off, too, once you drop the suit and developed pictures at the office.

She sounds happy. Been working too hard, having me miss appointments. Needs a break.

About five minutes later, she knocks on my door and I tell her to come in.

—Mr. York...

I hate hearing my own last name like that. I'm Steven, damn it. Can't get too friendly these days, though.

—Come in, I say. Speak freely, Deborah. Got something on your mind?

Of course she does. She walks in, closes the door behind her, and pulls a chair over to the front of my desk.

—I'm worried. More than a bit.

—About? Yeah, yeah, I know what *about*, but I had to ask.

She folds her hands on top of the desk and stares me down. — About this place. You've been out a lot, missing appoint...

I reach into the drawer and pull out the company checkbook. I carefully, in my nicest handwriting, spell out her name, and put three months' salary down on the amount. I sign it, and in the memo section, put "Performance Bonus." I slide the check over to her. For past and future *performance*. She deserves it.

—Deborah, I say, I could miss a hundred appointments, and still write out a hundred more of those before the funds start to go dry. Don't worry about your job. You're safe.

She sees the amount on the check; her eyes bulge a bit. Looks guilty, but she folds it and puts it on her lap like a piece of origami to be carefully preserved.

—It's not about money...

Then give the damned bonus back if it isn't. You're worried I'm going to tank this place. —I'll have the company pay the taxes on that, I reassure her.

—It's not *that*.

—It's all a matter of numbers, I say. You can keep that, and the account will figure out the tax part.

—Mr. ... *Steven*!

There, finally got you to say my name. You must be pissed.

—Just get me the suit and the film developed, I say, not in the unkind, curt way the words themselves suggest, but *softly*.

—Everyone *cares* about you, Steven.

I get up, go to the window and look out. The sun's still out. Life is

still good. I remember what Sandra looked like in her new blouse. The one I bought her. Life is *still* good.

—They have no reason to be worried about me, I lie. She must know it's a lie, but her paychecks won't bounce, so she accepts the lie and leaves me alone while I stand there, still staring out the window and watching Sandra in the air, in that blouse.

I'm going to wear a suit into the bar tomorrow at lunch that will make that young stuffed shirt envy me. Lot of nerve that guy had, thinking he was going *up* in the world. I already made it there. I'm there now. Standing at my window. More than a few million in clear cash in the company account, and I don't have to share it with anyone. Twenty happy employees. Yeah, yeah, a few pissed off clients who can't seem to get me into a meeting with them, but they'll take it a few more times before they let me know how pissed they really are.

I go to the desk, fetch the camera, and then realize I used all the film I'd bought with it. Need to get some more. Point the camera out the window anyway, but the vertigo hits when I put my eye to it. I reach for something to keep myself steady. Nothing to hold grab. Put the camera down to my waist. Vertigo clears up a bit. Sandra's not there anymore. Damn.

Go back to my desk and hit up Tim. —How's the Cranston account? I ask.

—I can *show* you, he says.

—*Do* that, then.

In a few minutes, he's at my desk, his blueprints all stretched out. I scribble a few changes here and there. — Fix it, bring it back for a sign off once you do, then courier it over to Cranston, and add a "With regrets about the missed appointment, emergency inspection at one of the sites" type note. Better check with Deborah to see which of the stock apologies she used, and echo that. By the way, you violated a bylaw in that thing.

—Huh?

I stare Tim down. —City zoning bylaw fifty-three dash whatever the hell subsection. Who cares which? Just don't do it again.

Tim looks over the changes I scrawled on his design.

—Damn, Steve. I didn't even notice that.

—That's why you don't get to sign off around here, Tim. Be more careful. People's *lives* are at stake.

—How do you *catch* that stuff so *quickly*?

I stare him down again until he slowly backs out of the room. Nice guy, but sloppy. —Oh, Tim, I add just before he closes the door.

—Yeah? he says, turning his head back to me.

—Get a nice suit. No more business casual around here. Suits and ties for the architects from now on. As of next Monday, it's The Law.

Something about "It's about bloody time" as he closes the door.

—And Tim! I yell after the door is shut. Door opens again, Tim peers in. —I meant what I said. One more screw up like that ... if it's one where people could get hurt ... and you're out of here.

Tim steps in, the door still open. Of course he doesn't look happy.

—You're very good, Tim. I'm trying to comfort him after laying *that* on him? —But close only counts in horseshoes.

He slinks out, closing the door again. Ha! That felt good. A drunken idiot telling the sober guy to shape up or ship out. I've still got it. I reach back into my usually locked drawer and pull out the flask. Damn.

* * *

It must be all of eight at night when I wake up with my face on the desk. The Healy account plans are under my cheek. I remember *that* much. I'd been going over the Healy account, making sure Tim didn't screw something up there, too. He didn't. At least not that I can remember before I fell asleep. The alarm must be set in the hall. I'll have thirty seconds to get from my door to the touch pad if I want to get out of here tonight without setting off the system. Screw it. I'll just sleep here and shower in the bathroom and put the suit on. Privileges.

* * *

I wake up again, and the suit's there, folded in front of me on the desk. The photographs are in their envelope, unopened. The note stuck to the suit reads, "Thanks for the bonus, Steven. I think navy is good for you." *Steven*. Thanks, Deborah. I appreciate that. The one person here who isn't going to be thrown off by next week's new dress code.

The suit fits nicely, except the legs are a bit long, so I fold up the cuffs and paperclip them on the inside. Nobody will notice. I walk down the hallway to the washroom, lock the door, and shower myself clean. The navy suit's back on, I'm out, shaved and clean, and sober.

John walks past me, does a double take.

—Mr. *York*?

—You get one by Monday, John. But only I'm allowed to wear navy.

—Huh?

—New dress code.

John's halfway down the hallway before he lets out — Shit!

I like being able to do that.

Ten. Still have time to kill, so I go back to my box and open the envelope.

A roll taken of an empty bench. Where she and I sat only minutes before. *Wonderful*. Half a roll on a couple holding hands. Mostly the hands. *Wonderful*. The next half of the roll on Sandra at work. She's not wearing the blouse I bought her, but she's beautiful. And that smile. It changed. The bench did that; I can see it.

Someone knocks, so I shove the photos back into the envelope. — It's open.

Tim. Can't tell if he's happy or pissed. One of those halfway looks on his face. He shuffles his feet around, comes in. He has an envelope in his hand that doesn't look like my morning mail.

—You resigning? I ask, only half half-serious. His face flushes. *Got* him.

I could put the envelope in the Cuisinart, unopened, you know, Tim. The Healy plans were fine, after all. Not so much as a ventilation shaft off by even a smidgen.

—Just asking for a leave of absence, he finally admits.

—In the middle of the Healy and Cranston accounts?

We haven't even started laying the foundations yet.

Tim looks left, up, right, down, as if he's trying to find words. He puts the letter on my desk, signaling for me to read it.

—Home stress, he says.

I don't care, Tim. Sorry I was so hard on you last night. Stick around for the Healy and Cranston accounts. It'll pass. —I don't need to know about it, I finally reply. I care ... but your life is *your* business.

—Laura's been talking divorce. I'm not on the mark around here. You saw that. Bylaw violations? C'mon. That was *stupid* of me.

—I was too hard on you yesterday, Tim. Take it easy, will you? That's why I'm here ... to catch the kind of thing.

—That's why I want a few months off, he explains.

—Starting?

It's in the letter. Starting *immediately*. Well, John can take over those accounts, if you bring him up to speed, I suppose. That's a week at least. Can't leave just like *that*, Tim.

—I've already brought John up to speed on the plans.

Nice of John to tell me. What the hell else don't I know is going on around here?

—OK, Tim. Fix it all up, fix *yourself* up, and get back here when you feel like it.

Tim looks down at the ground. His hands are in his pockets and he's kicking at the ground like there's something else. Something else usually means *money*.

—Leave of absence with *full* pay. Take as long as you *need*.

He looks up, eyes wide open, like I just said exactly what he needed to hear.

—I appreciate it, Steve.

—Get out, I say, waving him. Fix it all up. Make *sure* you come back wearing a suit, though, OK?

Tim laughs as he closes the door. Measured time crawls by too slowly when you're sober. The vertigo hits me a few times, but I force it away by closing my left eye for a rest. Where does that come from? It's not the booze. Never did that to me before. It's something else. Get

behind me, Satan.

The Cuisinart is staring at me, so I throw the letter in. Doesn't matter. I'll just tell Deborah to keep putting his payroll check in front of me to sign, until he decides to come back. If he does. Those divorce things can do a man over. I open the other locked drawer and take all of Anne's pictures out, and throw them into the shredder, too. One at a time. Bye. Bye. Bye. About time I did that. What else can I shred? The decree? No. That probably has something in it that my lawyer needs to remind me about one day. Always a clause. A catch. A hitch of unfinished business.

Finally. Time to go. I get up, brush my hair back with my hand, and head out. Walk past George, who's filling in for Deborah.

—Got a call about your car. It was parked too long and was towed.

That's what I get for taking a taxi back to the office. Forgot all about the Jaguar. Wonder if the towing company scratched it?

—Call me a cab, I reply. Pay the fine out of petty cash and get the Jag back here by the end of the day.

Cab comes, I get in, and tell him to go to the bar. Pay the fare, get out, and take a deep breath.

OK, I'm going to walk in there, and make a decision.

Sprite or Caesar. Sprite or ... ah, to hell with it.

—Caesar, I tell Sandra as I take my usual seat at the bar.

Her eyes are all wide, like she hardly knows me, but she's smiling. And she decided to wear the blouse to work. Looks great on her.

—Very nice suit! she says as she pushes the Caesar my way. —Did you buy that for li'l ol' me? She's grinning.

I grin back at her. —I haven't worn a suit like this since ... since, hell, I can't remember. The Caesar goes back, the pain disappears a bit. What *is* that?

—Very suave.

I give her my best Bogart look. I have more than the sneer down, so I pick something friendlier.

Just as I had hoped, the young stuffed shirt takes a spot at the bar. Doesn't seem to recognize me, so I say,

—1976.

He stares at me, then catches a clue as to whom is speaking to him.
—Nice suit.

—That was a good year for me, I replied, sitting straighter. Ha, didn't think I could pull off a suit, eh? Thought you invented wearing the damned things? Asshole.

Sandra leans over to me and says, —By the way, the guy you threw the drink at yesterday is *really* pissed.

Oh, that. So, I threw a drink in Satan's face and he hasn't gotten over it yet. So what?

—Talking about *suing*.

—Same time off as yesterday? I ask.

Sandra smiles a yes back, and I motion for another Caesar. I can't stop laughing. If you aren't going to get behind me, then get in line, Satan, get in line.

Mike comes out to tell Sandra something, sees me, and nearly falls over. He's pissed at me for what I did the day before. All that legal talk scares him.

—A sissy, I say. It was just a drink. Nothing going to *kill* him. Except I captured his soul on film and then ruined the roll in the light. Those might have been something to see if I'd still had them when I told Deborah to develop the rolls. Won't ruin the roll of Satan next time.

—Well, he's really pissed.

I'm sure he has a good lawyer, too. Satan's advocate. Didn't do Anne any good against *mine*, though, did he? Screw him. Mine's better. I push my business card over to Mike and say, —If he has any questions about whom to sue, give him my card.

The stuffed shirt seems to be listening to all of this. Motions to me to hand him one of my cards, which I do.

—What kind of buildings do you design?

Prisons. Boxes. Mausoleums. Torture chambers. — High end, I say.

—Do you do interiors?

Stupid idiot. I'm not running an interior decoration place. *Interiors*? What is this guy *about*? —If York didn't do the outside, we

don't do the inside, I reply.

—We're looking for a new presence.

Presence? Oh, Jesus, this guy's a riot. —Tell him what I charge for *presence*, Sandra.

Sandra walks over to the shirt and whispers something in his ear. He goes pale, just like I knew he would. —You did the *Courthouse*?

Presence. Anyone wants to sue me, they have to do it in the place I designed. I know where to hide there. I know the acoustics. I know where the secret doors out of the place lead. I know how many cubic feet each judge has to sit and read the paper before he wipes his ass with the judgment. *Presence.* Idiot. I want to take the camera and catch that stupid look on film, but I haven't bought any new rolls yet.

—I suppose I could do *presence*. One time thing. Have your boss call me.

He sits straighter. —I'm the owner.

Oh, Jesus, Joseph, and Mary. The *owner*? I took you for the mail sorter. What kind of *presence* does this prick want? High tech. Take the corporation to the next level.

—You want to go to the next level based on *interiors*?

—Our present location is not in keeping with where we want to go. The interior feel is very important.

We. Mighty important. *We.* So regal. I thought you *owned* the thing. *We.* Just went public. Ah, want to burn public money on *presence*. Where do these clones *come* from? Didn't that go the way of the dot-bombs?

—Call me when you need *presence*, I say, getting up. Sandra's out in no time and we head down the street, her on my arm, just like yesterday. Towards the bench. Things went *great* there yesterday. Maybe good things can happen in pairs. Nothing shitty's happened yet. No, Tim left; that wasn't good. I'll call that the shitty thing that has to happen so that the good thing can follow without it being a run.

—How has it been? she asks.

I don't want to talk, Sandra. Let's just walk. You in your blouse, me in my new suit, and that stuffed shirt back in the bar thinking up ways to spend public money on *presence*.

—Think that guy will really sue?

Who cares about Satan, Sandra? He's lost. Looking for a new lawyer. Who cares about him? —It was just a drink in his face. What's he going to claim? Loss of appetite?

She laughs. The sun is on her hair, on her chest, down the skin of her arms. I wish I had some film so I could catch her in the new blouse. We head to the place I bought the camera; I pick up a few rolls. I want *her* on that bench, not just the empty shots I took after she'd gone back to work yesterday.

She resists but lets me finish a few rolls on her. Doesn't say a word, just sits there, in the sunlight, smiling with her eyes. People walking by see this guy in a new suit, snapping shots. Must figure she's a model. Then why am I in the suit? Some photographer. I've still got it.

The vertigo hasn't hit the whole time. You finally behind me, Satan?

—Want copies? I ask.

Sandra smiles at me and says, —No, it's OK.

I sit down, put my arm around her. It feels good. She feels good. Behind me *yet*, Satan?

No, he's sitting across the street, with those green and red and whatever the hell that other color is eyes, glaring at me, pointing at his watch. Tapping it like I have an appointment with him. I point him out to Sandra. He's *stalking* me.

—Why is he pointing at his watch? she asks.

—I've missed so many appointments this week, I don't care, I say.

She has no clue what I'm on about. Appointment with the guy I threw the drink at the day before? Maybe that explains why I was pissed enough to do that. Not a stranger.

—So sue me! I yell across the street as I give him the finger.

The look on his face is classic. I don't want him on the same roll as Sandra, so I put in the last roll and catch his grimace and he gives me the finger back. Asshole.

Doesn't matter, Sandra. Just let's sit here again, like yesterday. Now we're both wearing something new. He'll find his lawyer. But I know that Courthouse too well. I know where to hide. Where the escape

routes are. The acoustics. I built the damned place, after all. And my lawyer's better than whatever lawyer he manages to find. Ask Anne.

The Buick

—Who in God’s name has the last name Buick?

—I don’t know, Deborah replies over the set, but he’s on line four.

Buick. Before tapping in line four, I swing around to my keyboard and type in Buick. The Internet assures me it’s a surname. I’ll be damned.

—Steven York, I mumble to the real person with the odd name I’d never imagined would be attached to a real person.

—This is Lawrence Buick ... from the bar, he says.

It’s the “from the bar” part that clues me in. Christ on a Crutch. The stuffed shirt “owner” of the high-tech company that just went public. *Figures* he’s got a last name like *that*. How did he find my ... right, I shoved him my card when he asked.

I can’t help myself. I just have to ask, —Do you drive one?

Asked that all the time. No. BMW. Right. This is the guy who asked if the firm does *interiors* because his corporation needs *presence*. I can’t remember what I was thinking when I told him we’d do it for him, once in a lifetime thing.

—I’ve got a great concept on that, I lie. *No Exit* is staring at me from the bookshelf. —How about Second Empire?

Second Empire, what’s that, you ask? Second Empire is for places where you can check in but you can never leave, buddy. What’s the name of “your” corporation, anyway? Certainly not Buick. Wouldn’t that be a trademark violation or something? Desoto, maybe. No, I’m the Desoto, you’re the Citroën. There’s an accent on that, buddy. Upwardly futile.

—I'm jaggig you around, Larry. Yeah, that's what I drive. A Jaguar. BMW? Did you buy *that* with your IPO dollars, too? *Presence*. I'll give your new place *presence*.

—I'm excited to know that the firm that did the Courthouse is going to do Bentatronic Corporation's new presence.

Bent-a-what-the-hell? Oh man. You *need* us, buddy. Ah, speaking in the definite. I haven't agreed to actually *do* it, have I? Can't remember; I was drunk. We're an *architectural* firm. We don't *do* interiors of places unless we *built* them. We're *not* interior decorators.

—Why not go from the ground up? I ask.

—Ground up?

—You want a whole new location, right? Why lease? Buy some land and have us do the *whole* concept, from the ground up, Larry. We're an *architectural* firm.

What kind of money are we talking about here, Steve? Steve. Ha. Mr. York to you, Larry. Buick or not. Or at least don't drop the en. Steven. As in *even*. Even Steven.

—Larry, Larry. You've seen the Courthouse, haven't you? Do you think I like signing off on stuff that's going to *vanish*? I do the fingers wiggling in the air, then realize I'm on the phone and he won't fall for the prestidigitation. Interiors vanish. They go away. You want *lasting* *presence*, don't you? Buicks are built to *last*.

It's public money. IPO funding. Too much burning will get you in trouble. That's what I'm hoping for,

asshole. Let's build a legacy for you that gets you canned as CEO. Your parachute will keep you from hitting the ground *too* hard on the way down. And by the way, when you went public, you stopped being the "owner"—get over that, will you? I'm an owner. I only spend the money I *earn*.

—Let us do a concept. Then *you* decide, I finally suggest.

He goes for it. Great. After I hang up, I hit up John's extension. — Give me a concept on a high-tech building that *nobody* could turn down, I say. I want the client to buy in, even if it costs his soul. Everything you've got. Spare no projected expense.

—Got a name for me?

—Bent-a-what-the? ... *Bentatronic* Corporation.

The hums, the haws, then, —Didn't they *just* go public?

—Pretend like there's no roof on the budget. Concept: Tower of Babel. Sky's the limit, John. Ha. That's it. At Ben-a-*what-the-hell* Corporation, the Sky's the Limit. We speak in tongues. —Oh, and just for giggles, throw a Buick in the concept art somewhere. Something from 1976. 1976 Buick Century. Yeah.

—Huh?

Concept art, John. Concept. Run with it. What *concept* is 1976? That's the year "Hotel California" was released. It was my best year. Why do I have to explain that?

Oh, Larry the Shirt will love it. He'll be drooling over it. He'll *have* to have it for Bentatronic Corporation, and he'll spare no expense to get it. Not *his* money, after all.

—Deborah, I say after the finger dance on the keypad, could you have eleven roses sent to ... what's the address? What's the address of a *bar* you always go to but

never think about sending a letter or package to? *The Cradle on Sixth*.

—The bar?

No, the cradle to the grave, silly. Yes, the bar, the bar, what do you think? The bar. Yes. Eleven.

—Yes, Mr. York. But to whom?

—Have the florist just put: "These are not for Mike" and it will get to the right person, I instruct her.

—You're insane, Mr. York, she replies.

Yes. Insane. But in a good mood, so what's it to you, Deborah?

★ ★ ★

—The roses are beautiful, Sandra says. She's in a new skirt. One that matches the pale blue blouse I bought her.

—But why eleven? Is there a message in that somewhere? I want to kiss her again but hold my ground a bit longer. —The message is

that you are the twelfth rose, I

explain, smiling. It feels good to be smiling again.

She blushes, and I *really* want to kiss her. Last three have been on the cheek. This time, I lean over to her, and just before I kiss her cheek, move over to her lips. She tastes good. The kiss lingers. She returns it. I don't want to stop.

But Satan's over on the other side of the street, staring at us, like the stalker he is. I pull away, take a deep breath, and the vertigo hits me. Damn. Not now!

—That was *nice*, she says.

Yes, it was. I haven't kissed a woman like that since everything broke apart with Anne. I take a quick glance over at Satan, and Sandra notices.

—Get a restraining order on him, she says. He's starting to creep me out.

—Has he been showing up at the bar? I ask.

—No, not since he stormed in and threatened to sue.

Over a drink in the face. Why can't he just get *over it*?

Well, that, and I stole his soul. Speaking of which, here are those photos of you, Sandra.

—Wow, she says when she sees them. You really have an eye.

An evil eye. It's the left eye that gives me the vertigo. Or maybe something behind it. Whatever it is that hurts so much, behind the left eye. —You make for an easy subject, I protest.

I start to wobble over, and she puts her soft hand on my right shoulder to catch me. Such nice hands. Strong from working at the bar, but not harsh.

—You really have to get that checked, she says. She's not smiling anymore. I want you to smile, Sandra.

—Already went to the doctor, I admit. Results not in yet.

—You should take better care.

It's too late for that. Satan is across the street, waiting for me, Sandra. It's too late to take care. The second he gets *his* soul back, he wants mine. Thing is, I don't know *how* to give him his back. I destroyed the first set of negatives anyone's ever used on him. He's

screwed, and so am I.

—I promise I will, I say. You make me want to. I didn't *care* before.

* * *

—Dr. Frobisher's office called, Deborah says as I return to the firm.

I nod my acknowledgement and head for my office. Once in, I unlock the drawer at my desk, take out the flask, and empty the vodka into me before picking up the phone and dialing Frobisher's office.

There's a long wait. Frobisher wants me to come in to give me the results. I set up a time later that same afternoon. They'll fit me in. When I hang up, I punch up John's extension.

—How's the Bentatronic concept thing coming? I ask. He'll have something for me by tomorrow, noon. Good. Better be something that Larry the Shirt can't turn his head at, or you're fired, John. No. Can't fire you. You're doing Tim's accounts now, too. I love you, John.

Keep up the good work.

—Deborah, can you come into my office?

She's there almost the moment the phone is down on the hook. How does she do that?

—Are you OK, Steven? There she goes again. Second time she's said my first name in a week. Of course, she knows if the doctor's office phoned, there must be something up. Good timing with the first name, Deborah. You're a pro at this office protocol thing; know just when to drop it by the wayside. I wave her in and signal the Door Close.

—No, I admit.

She looks pale, so I tell her to sit down.

—Deborah, I begin, I've been having some pretty *bad* vertigo. Last couple of weeks. *Really* bad. And a terrible pain behind my left eye. Went for some tests. The doctor has the results, and I'll be getting them

this afternoon. I have no idea what it is, but somehow I think it's not just an inner ear infection. The SERC the doctor gave me in the meantime isn't helping.

She's paler. —I hope it's nothing...

Hope springs eternal. It's the only thing that didn't escape Pandora's Box. Did you know that? I want you to promise me something, Deborah. Promise me that this Bentatronic Corporation concept goes to account and dries the stuffed shirt out. Take that Buick for everything he has. Ruin him.

—I'm putting you in charge of Lawrence Buick, I finally say. She's always wanted a promotion from front office manager to account manager. —I hate to lose a good office manager, but I think you're ready for accounts.

She says something about not wanting to get promoted if it's going to come because I can't do it because of my health. No, no, you're *ready*, Deborah. You take over the Lawrence Buick thing. Turn it into an account and ruin him. Ruin him ragged, understand? Ruin him like you *mean* it.

—I was waiting for the last two months for the perfect prospect to hand you, I admit. The divorce threw me, all the court stuff. But this Bentatronic thing ... this is what I've been waiting for. Don't screw it up. I know *you* won't.

Where do I want you to take it? *Ruin* him. Drag him into the net and get him to spare no expense. Take the Buick for a ride. Get him to spend the IPO funding on *presence* until he has no more to spend.

—Can I phone you at home tonight, to find out about your results? she asks. She's got standing orders to never phone me at home unless a client's roof is leaking. Since I don't design leaky roofs, she's never phoned me at home.

—I'll tell you when I tell you. Don't phone, please. I want to ruin that Buick guy. Oh my God, did I admit that out loud to Deborah?

Her eyes bulge.

—You want me to take on an account of someone you want to ruin? Her smile grows. Ah, I knew you were the right one for the job, Deborah. —Why?

Why on God's Green Earth did I let that one slip? Well, she's a co-conspirator now, so I might as well admit it. —Anne.

—Friend of Anne's?

No, no. But he's young. Just like George Deville. He's young, upwardly mobile, and represents something to me that I want to burn to the ground.

—String him into the net, I say aloud. Get him hard for this concept. Get him to build something that his grandchildren's grandchildren will admire as the most amazing corporate presence ever built. And get him to do it on his IPO funds. Take him down to the river.

Deborah smiles. —It's all the same to me, she says. An account's an account. His concept will become a reality. If it ruins him, well, that will be my present to you, she says as she leaves the office.

It's good to have employees who stand behind you.

Deborah always hated what Anne did to me.

* * *

OK, Dr. Frobisher, let me have it.

—Your vertigo is not an inner ear infection, he starts. Then he stands, goes over to a hanging picture of a head, and points near the left ear. —There's *pressure* here.

Just let me *have* it.

—And the scan shows that pressure is being caused by a tumor, *here*, he explains, pointing into the brain on the wall as if it were mine.

Shit. Do I even want to know what the prognosis is, Doctor?

Frobisher sits back down. The guy's been my doctor since I was Buick's age. He knows my vices. Been with me for every one. Even before I had them.

—Steven, let's face it. You're going to *die*. This is a *huge* tumor. Quite advanced. You're lucky to still be alive as it is.

Thanks, Bill. Thanks for all we've been through together. Thanks for not bullshitting me.

—I could tell you to give up drinking and smoking and all that, he adds, but you've got *maybe* a few months. No use. Unless you want to. Can't be absolutely sure about how long, but.... He's nodding his head the Nothing Can Be Done.

He shoves a bunch of my results towards me.

—So ... the pain going to get worse?

He smiles. It's not a happy smile, but more of a comforting thing, from what I can tell. The same smile he gave me when I found out Anne had miscarried, way back when. Frobisher's comforting smile is kind of half- and-half. Lots of practice. —In your condition, I can give you whatever you need for it to not be *intolerable*. To ease it. But that's a lot of drugs, and, well, you wouldn't function well at all.

Brain cancer. How can I function at *all* with that?

—But then, I'm surprised you haven't had more than the pain and the vertigo. It's *quite* advanced, Steven. You been hearing voices?

I've been seeing Satan, Bill. But wait, others have seen the guy, not just me. So that's *not* a delusion. He's threatened to sue, after all. He's real.

—Nothing out of the ordinary, I say. Get threatened with court all the time, but I built the Courthouse. Know it too well. Never lose a case. Ask Anne.

—Seeing things?

Satan's eyes are red and green and I don't know what the hell the other color is, Bill. And those six zombie clone corporate drones had the same color eyes at the bar. But Mike saw them, too. Nearly shit his pants.

—No.

—Just the vertigo and the pain? Not acting strange? Doing things you don't normally do? Spending money on anything out of the ordinary?

—Well, my feet go numb. I thought that was the drinking. And I threw a drink in Satan's face just because I felt like it.

—Could be.

He writes me a prescription for a very heavy dose of narcotic, and tells me to be careful if I drive, until I know how they will hit me.

—And I don't recommend you drink if you fill this out. Not because of the drinking, *per se*, but because it will make you much drowsier if you do. Very dangerous. Your liver doesn't matter much at this point.

What a guy. No bullshitting around. Smack? You want me to take smack? I'll just keep drinking, thank you very much.

—I'm sorry about this, Steven.

* * *

—And that's the concept, Mr. Buick, Deborah says, almost taking a bow.

Oh, Jesus, that was perfect. Larry the Shirt is sitting in his chair, beside the two other Bentatronic Corporation clones. All three are hard for it. I've sat through enough of these concept presentations to know. John's concept is perfect. Right down to the 1976 Buick Century he threw in the art. Deborah pulled it off like she was born for this. She must have been.

I fold my hands on the boardroom table, and say, — And *that* is where we at York can bring Bentatronic Corporation. *Zerstörung*. Total and absolute ruin. There's an accent on that, too, buddy, just like Citroën.

Deborah's eyes are aglow. She can smell the lust in the room. The *lust* these three guys have for what they were just promised. High tech *presence* that will take them to the next level. No expense spared. Burn, baby, burn.

Lawrence Buick turns his chair to face me. I can see it in his eyes; they're on fire. Not the same color as Satan's or those six clones, but getting there. He *wants*. He *wants*.

—I'll have to run this by the board, he finally says, as if there's some shame in his not having the final say on the matter.

—You have my vote, the other shirts chime in.

—Four more to convince, Larry says.

—Three against four. You'll win, I say as I leave the room and let

Deborah do the rest. My work here is done.

* * *

Sandra's kiss. It's still on my mouth. Too bad Satan had to be glaring at us from across the street. I'm still going over it in my head when Deborah walks in.

—That was perfect, I tell her. Perfection in motion. She smiles and bows.

—I'm dying, I then say, once the door's closed.

She's not smiling anymore. She just rushes up to me and hugs me. She feels good there. If it weren't for Sandra, I'd probably enjoy the hug more than I am. No, this is Deborah. I wouldn't go there with her even if Sandra hadn't entered the picture. I still have *some* decorum about me.

Crying? No. Just sort of sobbing.

—Brain cancer.

She stands back. Her eyes are all wet.

—So you have to promise me to finish off Buick, even if I ... Can I say it? — ... die before it's done.

No, I can't die before Buick goes down. I want to see that.

She and I say nothing more. I just let her hold me again, and really cry it all out.

* * *

—Sandra, I start, but can't think of anything to say other than her name.

She just sits with me on the bench, holding my hand. I don't want to lie to her about the results, but I don't want to put that on her if I don't have to, either. Not yet, anyway. It's too damned good with Sandra to go there. Too damned good.

Satan's decided not to pay a visit today, across the street. Maybe he's advising Buick on how to snooker the rest of the board. I have no clue what would happen if I die before I can give him his soul back. I don't know how. I exposed the film. Maybe his lawyer will figure something out in the terms.

The Small Claim

—Small claims? C'mon, Charlie, you've got to be kidding, I say I as shove the paperwork back across the table. His *lawyer* put *that* together? Who'd he hire, an articling student? I spear a shrimp from the salad and pop it in my mouth, and then put back half my Caesar.

Charlie shrugs. —The amount he's asking wouldn't get him anywhere higher than that.

But I *want* it to go to the Courthouse. If he does the small claims thing, it won't. —Can we counter *above* that? I ask.

—Huh?

Charlie, Charlie. If we go to small claims, your fee will be higher than what he's claiming as damages. If we bring our counterclaim higher than the limit, we'll go to the *Courthouse*. You know, the one I built. I want to watch him squirm there.

—I suppose we *could*, but what counterclaim?

—I don't know. I keep at my salad. Come up with *something*.

Charlie puts on his glasses and reads Satan's claim again. —Claims he had to replace his expensive glasses. That's almost seven hundred bucks. Doesn't have an extended plan, I guess. This lunch is costing you more than that in my time, he says.

Now you're starting to get it. It's a *nuisance* case, so if it's going to cost me anyway, let's bring it to the Courthouse, where his ass is *mine*.

—He's been stalking me, I say. Stalking must be against some law or other.

—Well, you can't *prove* he's stalked you, now, can you? No. So, that being the case, now that his lawyer has sent me *this*, he says,

pointing to the paper, he must remain at arm's length. Past is past, and if you can't prove it, didn't happen. Hearsay. Everyone and his dog saw you throw the drink in his face, however. He won't be stalking you *any longer*. Not without going to jail for *something*. So it effectively didn't *happen* that he stalked you. If you can't prove it, it didn't happen under the law.

Can't believe a lawyer said *that*. They'll say anything to keep the meter running.

—He's been causing Sandra a lot of distress. Showing up at the bar, sitting in the corner, brooding. Wants his soul back. *She* doesn't have it, and I don't anymore either. How about *her* emotional distress, then? Harassment?

—He can't even show up there, now that these are filed. Arm's length. His lawyer will tell him that much. So, get your mind off the whole stalking thing. Didn't happen.

You're the expert. What's wrong with his eyes that he needs glasses like *that*? They're red and green and I don't know what the hell the other color is. That's it. The glasses must hide that from everyone but me. Only I seem to notice them. Without those glasses, maybe someone else *will* notice. *He's* the one sweating over this. He's the one in emotional distress.

—Just be happy he didn't push for assault charges, Charlie says.

Oh, for Christ's sake, Charlie. I threw a salty Caesar in his face and took his picture as he stood there, covered in Clamato juice. *Assault*? Ha. It's not about the *glasses*. He wants to hide the color of his eyes, he can just close them. He can see with them closed. It's about his *soul*. He wants it back. I don't know how to give it back. No idea how. I ruined the negatives of that first shoot.

—On to *other* matters, he finally says.

The other matters aren't important to me, so I just let him rattle them off as we finish our lunch together.

* * *

—So, I tell Mike, he *did* decide to sue.

Mike shoves the drink my way. He's still pissed about the whole thing. —At least he's suing *your* ass and not the bar's. Thanks, Mike. So loyal. It's not like he's pissed at *you* over the whole thing. *You* didn't steal his soul. I did.

Then the damned vertigo hits. I know what it is now but haven't let on to Mike or anyone else around the bar. Especially not Sandra. Not yet, anyway.

—My ass? He's asking for less than seven hundred bucks. *Pocket change*.

—Just pay it.

—It's the *principle* of the matter, Mike.

—Not worth the hassle. Just *pay* it, for crying out loud.

That's *nothing* for you.

That's everything, Mike. If I cave on this, his articling student will find a way to work in something besides that money. Some hitch. Just like the divorce lawyer tried with Anne. Some little clause. But Charlie found *that* soon enough, so he'd likely ... no, he might miss it. Charlie thinks this is just a small claims thing.

That's *it!* Take it through something small, catch *my* lawyer off guard. Charlie is probably thinking *just pay it* like *you* are. The judge will be thinking that, too. Won't happen the way it happened with the divorce. Everyone took that *seriously*. Had some sympathy for me that time. He's *not* naïve. He's *Satan*, for Christ's sake. He's got *some* little clause, some rider, some settlement attachment in there. And I *did* throw it in his face. People saw it. No sympathy for me. Unless I can think of a good counterclaim and Charlie backs it up with some firepower at the Courthouse.

—Give me the phone, I tell Mike, and he does. I hate cells. Never carry one. Deborah is always ... *was* always. Now George bugs me about that. Deborah figured out I *wasn't* going to listen to her about carrying a cell, a few weeks before I promoted her to going after the Lawrence Buick account.

In a few minutes, I'm past Charlie's people and at Charlie's ear itself.

—Take a *good* look at those papers again, Charlie, I say.

—What am I looking for? he asks.

—I don't know. Something small. Something *almost* not noticeable. Something in the claim that doesn't quite ring. A flyspeck in a corner you didn't see the first few times you went over it. Something you haven't seen on any other....

—I'll be *damned*, he says. Yes, Charlie, you *will*. One day. Soon enough. For what we did to Anne. —Couple of numbers here. Just assumed they were notation on a precedent. Or the glass prescription. Just two numbers, with a colon between them.

Satan's articling student can quote Scripture to his purpose, Charlie. Didn't you know that? Don't assume anything. I should fire you and hire a new firm. What are the numbers?

—One colon twelve.

Nothing *else*? No name? No words? Just 1:12?

Prescription? 1:12? C'mon.

—That's it. And how much he wants to replace the glasses.

I just hang up. This guy costs by the second, so he doesn't mind if I just do that.

—I know this is a stupid question, Mike, but do you have ... I look left and right to make sure nobody is close enough to hear me, — ... a *Bible* handy?

Mike starts to laugh so hard he nearly splits open. He's slapping his thigh. Finally, he can tell I'm serious. — Maybe in one of the drawers of the rooms?

Yes. The attached hotel. Send someone to get one. — Sandra's on now, so I'll do it, he says as he wipes down the bar from his shift.

Sandra shows up, smiling. She and I are getting along well now. Kissing on the mouth. She smells wonderful. New perfume. Vanilla?

—Yes! You notice these things! she says, smiling wider.

Of course I do, Sandra. I've got brain cancer, not a missing nose. Five minutes later, Mike is back with a Bible from one of the rooms. I crack it open, right in front of Sandra. Oh, Jesus, she must figure I've found religion or something. No, Sandra, I'm looking at 1:12. Don't

know which book, though. This *is* “notation on a precedent” as Charlie put it. Just not the same kind he’s used to seeing.

And the Earth brought forth grass ... no, not Genesis. Wait. This is Satan we’re talking about here, after all.

Let me ... *Job*. That’s it. Job 1:12. *And the LORD said unto Satan, Behold, all that he hath is in thy power; only upon himself put not forth thine hand. So Satan went forth from the presence of the LORD.*

There we go! If I pay for the glasses and this gets settled, he’ll have power over *what I have*. It’s on the claim’s form. Weasel-worked in. Jimmied alongside the cost of the specs. Charlie *missed* that? Not power over me—he bungled *that* one—but over Sandra.

I do the Phone signal with my hand, and Sandra hands it to me. Charlie’s back on soon enough.

—Find a way to get this into the Courthouse, I insist.

—Steven, it’s *small claims*. Don’t sweat it, for crying out loud.

Is not small, Charlie. Job 1:12, buddy. If he wins, he has *power over what I have*, don’t you get it? He can’t have me, so he’s going for Sandra. Through a loophole his articling student wiggled in there under your highly paid nose. I can take him on at the Courthouse because I *know* that place. I *built* that place. I don’t know where the hell it is going to go in some small claims venue. Find a way to bring this up a notch, OK?

—I’ll try to find a way, he says before hanging up on *me* this time. Thanks for saving me a few cents, Charlie, because if you hadn’t hung up, I’d have said a few choice words your way that you would have had to bill me for. Don’t *try*, by the way, *do it*.

—What’s going on? Sandra asks.

I don’t know what to say: that Satan’s suing me and if he wins, he’s got his hooks on *her*, or that I’ve only got a few months to live? —Let’s just forget it, I finally come up with. It’s the first time in a while that I haven’t said my words kindly at her, but she’s still smiling and smelling wonderful. Nothing is going to ruin what she and I have. Or take it from me. Not while there’s breath in these lungs. Even if breathing *does* hurt.

* * *

Dinner was great, Steven. Thanks, Sandra. You still smell good, even after working a whole day with that on. How do you *do* that? I've never smelled anyone so sweet.

—That's it! I exclaim. She's looking at me like I'm nuts. Crazy like a fox. Something Charlie said over lunch. Maybe the way she was eating her salad brought that back to me. *Just be happy he didn't lay assault charges*. That's it! Next time I catch him watching me, I'll go over and pop him in the nose and *force* the thing higher. No. I've *never* hit *anyone*. A few drinks in faces, but never *hit*.

Sandra smiles again, a lot with her eyes, and I imagine that she is worth popping Satan in the nose over. Got to get it to the Courthouse if I'm going to win this one. Can't let him settle it small claims. Worth trying, anyway. She's worth it. My turn to stalk him and punch his lights out. Bring it up a notch.

* * *

—Your apartment is *amazing* she says, near the window.

Yes. Steven York builds things to last. Amazing things. Steven York builds amazing things. God, you're gorgeous, Sandra.

—I bet the rent here is sky high.

Rent? Oh, Sandra. That's why you're so great. So naïve. I love you, you know. I *own* this building, this Tower of Babel. I *built* it. Should I tell you, or just nod as if I pay rent? You know I have money, but not how much. I'm not your average barfly. I only smelled like one, until I started to get to know you. Let's keep it that way. Nod. Half of this *should* be Anne's, you know. Except she screwed around on me and made the mistake of admitting during statements that *she* abandoned me. That's where Charlie did his best work. Prenups. She could have gotten half of this, but for that slip of the tongue.

I *own* this place, Sandra. This whole cursed building. Don't you

know that's why Satan has his eye on what's mine? He has his eye on you, on this place, on the whole thing I built. I should have thought twice before throwing that drink in his ugly squash, I know. *Should* have, *could* have. But you and I just got back from our first hour together, out on the bench, in the sun. I was feeling frisky. Stupid, stupid. Charlie can fix that, though.

Nodding the Yes isn't really a lie. The people in this building who *do* pay rent, pay me enough. Well, the *company* gets paid, and I am the company. So it's not a Big Lie to nod Yes back at her. —Yes, the rent is sky high here. She thinks I have "some" money but doesn't know how much Anne missed out on. Charlie's doing. Maybe I'll leave it all to *you* in the will. Anne can't have it now, so it's either you, charity, or the employees at the firm.

The phone rings, and even though I don't want to, I pick it up. It's Charlie. Something about how the articling student got the date moved up to next Monday. Where does an articling student get the connections to do *that*? These things take time to get to court, even in small claims. Find a way to push it far enough up—just not so far that I'm dead already—and then get it into the *Courthouse*, Charlie. I don't know *how*, but there's no way in hell I'm going to face Satan next *Monday* in any old random venue. Hey, wait, if I take a running leap ... I'm going to die in a few months *anyway* ... I could do that. No, Sandra and I haven't even made love yet, and I don't want to die before that, and tonight I want to stay just the way it is with her. Push it off. Find a way. Delay it and put it up a notch. Get it the hell out of small claims and into the *Courthouse* where we can deal with it like men. Like we dealt with Anne.

We go out onto the balcony and watch the stars. My arm is around her. Maybe she and I *should* make tonight the night we make love. What if Charlie's lost his grip on things and can't get it moved to the ideal venue? What if Satan ends up with Sandra, and this Tower, and everything that's mine? Every damned thing I built without his help. What if next Monday is my curtain call? Charlie's losing his grip on things. I kiss Sandra's ear, and she faces me and responds.

Kiss me longer, Sandra. Maybe then I can leap off the balcony, and

screw Satan out of the whole nine. I took his soul, and if I die before the small claims thing goes through, he doesn't get the Job 1:12 treatment. Yes, kiss me longer. Bring me to life again, just before I leap. No, you're too nice. I can't jump right in front of you. That's *sick*. I'm not a cruel person. Not to you.

I put my arm down around her waist. She's perfect. Satan wants her. He wants what he can't have, and he thinks he and his articling student are going to pull it off with a trick of the pen. Nobody but me knows what 1:12 means on the claim.

And as I have my arms around her, her mouth and mine together, totally in the moment, it comes to me. The counterclaim. I don't want to break off the kiss. It's too damned perfect. Too good. But if I don't call Charlie while the counterclaim idea is still in my head ... if Sandra and I end up making love first, I'll forget it. My brain isn't working the same these days; I'll forget this great idea of mine, and it will all be Satan's.

No. I break off the kiss, but not in a way that will make Sandra think I'm pulling away. —Why don't you find the bedroom? I suggest. I have just one more call to make.

She smiles and then retreats inside to find the bedroom of my upscale mansion in the sky, so near Heaven, but since this is the Tower of Babel, not quite there before the tongues got all mangled.

I dial Charlie's home number. —I've got the counterclaim that will bring this up a notch and out of small claims, I say.

Charlie's listening as I explain. I took a second roll of film of him, you see. The next day. I'd already screwed him out of his soul on the first roll, but this second one was a keeper. After he'd already decided to sue me but hadn't filed yet. His intent was there, Charlie. He told Mike he was going to *sue*, and then when he saw me, he flipped me the bird. Yeah, yeah, so what if I flipped him off first. I caught *him* on film. If he doesn't have any evidence that I flipped him off first, then I never did. You said that yourself. If it can't be proven, it didn't happen. Your words, Charlie, not mine.

Sandra and I were on the bench again, and he was across the street. I caught him on film, giving me the finger. I still have that roll

somewhere. Didn't get it developed yet. But if Sandra testifies as to the date and time of that photo, then I can prove that asshole is *harassing* me. That's *not* a small claim thing. It *really* disturbed her. He's giving me the finger, Charlie, and she was with me, right there. It was plain as day. In fact, by filing this nuisance suit, with that photo ... well, you can put two and two together, can't you? *Clear* pattern of harassment.

I can almost hear him nodding. Never let your lawyer do *all* your thinking for you. Satan's got another thing coming if he thinks he and his articling student are going to bring this to small claims. This is Sandra we're talking about here. This goes to small claims in some back closet venue over my dead body. It goes to the Courthouse, or nothing.

As I walk towards the bedroom, mixing the drinks I've made for me and Sandra, I can't help but chuckle. Imagine that ... to come up with *that* while kissing her. Satan is screwed now. Serves you right for serving a nuisance suit my way. There's no way in hell you're getting power over what is *mine*. Not now that I have Sandra. Just wait until I have you at the Courthouse. I built *that* place. Doesn't stand a chance there. I know it down to the acoustics, asshole.

I'm almost at the bedroom door when the phone rings again. It could be Charlie with questions he can bill me to ask, so I go pick it up. —I'm on my way! I holler to Sandra, who's now in the bedroom.

It's Deborah.

—I *know* I'm not supposed to call you at *home*, she says. Right, Deborah. Especially *now*. This had *better* be good. —But I wanted you to know that we signed on the Lawrence Buick account this afternoon.

Ha! Things couldn't be better. Deborah was charged with making *certain* we got that account. Take Lawrence Buick for a ride. Get him slobbering over our concept for "his" corporation, just out of being private, newly public, and get him to burn all his IPO funding on our new corporate look and feel. Take that upwardly mobile asshole down by the riverside for a baptism by the Fire of Pride Goethe Before the Fall, where he belongs. Serves him right for spending public funds on company *presence*. Deborah *did* it. —Pat yourself on the back hard, I say, before hanging up and getting back to the bedroom door.

Maybe good does travel in pairs and triplets without something

shitty having to come in between. Maybe it happens only when you know you're going to die soon, and you give up looking for shitty things to focus on during the in-betweens. Maybe you have to be right at the door before it just happens uninterrupted by that kind of thing.

Satan's losing his touch, and I've still got mine. See you in court, I say to myself as I go into the bedroom. Small claims my ass. See you in the house that *Steven York* built.

Sandra looks amazing. I offer her the drink I've stirred for her, and she takes it. —I tend bar *here*, I say, as I slide between the sheets with her.

Nothing's going to change my world. Charlie's going to *earn* his fee this time. Not like with Anne. That was a gimme. And we're going to make Satan dance on *my* turf.

The Wake-Up Call

When I wake up, Sandra's beside me. Just where she should be. Why did I wait so long, Sandra? I've been sitting drinking at *The Cradle on Sixth* since Adam named the animals in the fields according to their kind. He'd reached the panthers just about the time I first saw you. Now I've got this damned thing in my brain and I'm going to die, and here we are, in bed. Finally.

Well, of course there was Anne, then. But it was mostly over for years, anyway, so what did it really matter? I'm too nice a guy, I guess. Had to wait for her to screw me over, leave, and then let myself *really* think about you. What a waste I didn't just move sooner.

I slide the sheets off her and just watch her breathe. It doesn't hurt when she breathes. I can see that. She's got a lot of time yet. Not with me, though. Maybe I should tell her.

No. I get out of bed, pull on my shorts, and head for the living room. What's the use of owning a place like this if you can't enjoy it with someone? Built it for Anne. Every angle of every room is Anne. I'm not sentimental, so I didn't have to leave after the crap started. I didn't have to get out of this space to forget. I didn't need to forget that she's in every shadow. The way I planned every board in the floor. The tenants in the other apartments don't know that they're walking on Anne every time they wander through *their* kitchen units.

The balcony door is still open. I must have forgotten to close it when I came back inside and went to the bedroom. The curtains are blowing in, then out. I light up a smoke and stand outside in my shorts, and just let the wind do one over on me. It feels good. You're the wind,

Sandra. Anne's the corner, the boards in the floor, the ceiling, the joints of this place, but you're the wind blowing through the balcony door.

OK, Satan. Here I am. Forty days and forty nights of fasting. Well, forty minutes. More or less. Yeah, yeah, I know I'm not Jesus, and if I jump, the angels aren't going to catch me, but here I am anyway. Let's settle this thing out of court. Let's do it right here, buddy. Me in my shorts. Bring your lawyer along if you want to make sure I'm not going to pull one over on you.

Ah, well, then, see you in court. No show!

—It's nice out here.

I turn to see Sandra standing at the balcony door, naked. The wind is making play with her hair. I can almost hear her music. I motion for her to join me at the rail.

—I built this place for the view, I say as I put my arm around her waist. Her skin is smooth.

—*You* built this place?

—Yes. I didn't tell you earlier. Thought that would be bragging. This is a York building. I own *it*, too. How does one say something like that without seeming to try to impress?

She's quiet. Maybe I'm intimidating her. —I feel silly for saying the rent must be high! she finally admits. Even in this light, I can see the blush on her cheeks. Don't worry, Sandra, the wind will blow that away.

—No, no, I assure her. My hand is gently stroking her right buttock, hers my left.

—I've never known anybody as rich as you, she says.

I want to laugh, or cry, or both. It's all meaningless, don't you see? Money *can* buy you love; that's not what I mean. It just doesn't *mean* anything. Standing here with you means something, Sandra. Let's talk about something else.

—Being wealthy means you get sued a *lot*, I say.

She turns to look at me. Her eyes are smiling, but I can see something else in them now. Maybe she can see past my left eye, into my brain, and sees the cancer there, eating at me. Maybe she knows. Maybe she knows and just hasn't had the heart to let me in on the

secret.

—You're not the same person I imagined you were, she finally says, still staring into my brain.

What to tell her? That I *am* the asshole she always imagined? That I built my little petty empire by not caring what it did to Anne and my marriage? That I let Anne wander away from me, have an affair, and then took her to the cleaners on a prenuptial technicality? That I've crushed more than a few human beings Under the Law for crossing me? That I'm a living picture of Dorian Gray? What to tell this sweet, innocent woman? Has she even *read* Wilde's book?

—Ever read *The Picture of Dorian Gray*?

—Yes, I have, she replies.

I'll be damned. There's more to Sandra than I imagined, too, I guess. Now how am I going to reply to *that*?

—Well, imagine that my brain is the picture.

She looks more intently at my eyes. —Is it old and corrupted, and all ...

—Sandra, please, I say, turning away. This is getting too close for comfort, and I don't want to ruin the rest of the evening. What am I doing bringing up *that* book at a time like this? —I'm not a bad person. Why on Earth am I defending my character? I'm a *prick*!

—I know you're not. You're just deeper than I thought at first. I've known a *lot* of barflies in my time. You don't quite fit that role.

In your time? How old *are* you, Sandra? Is there some picture locked away somewhere that betrays *your* true age? Just as if she's heard me, she says, —Thirty. Been tending bar since I was twenty. Ten years of barflies. None like you. She leans forward and kisses the bridge of my nose. Her breasts are pressed against me. I put my arms around her and pull her closer.

It's now or never. Let her know about the cancer in there. About my corrupted and dying brain. She's probably already seen it, anyway. Just open my mouth and say it. —I've got... That's *it*. The words don't go past that. They won't. My tongue won't let them. It's too perfect. She doesn't need to know. Not yet.

—You've got wood, she laughs.

Of course I do, standing with you pressed against me like this. I'm not dead *yet*.

—I was twenty-three in 1976, I say. The year “Hotel California” came out. Just finished university. Ready to take on the world and build my Tower of Babel.

She looks up, does some math. —Twenty-three years on me. That's not so bad. You still are *fit*. Ah, she doesn't know then. She's looking at my body, not my brain. Yes, the body still has the appearance of health. —But you never *did* tell me what the doctor said was giving you those headaches.

Half my age ago, all that. A good year, 1976. Half my age ago.

—I've got cancer up there. Oh, God, it came out my lips.

She holds me closer. Doesn't say a word, just holds me closer. I didn't ruin it by telling her. She's still holding me and isn't crying the way Deborah did when I told her. Funny that. Told my employee, and *she* cried. Here I am, with a new lover, and she's just holding me, not crying *at all*. Sandra, you're an odd one, you are.

—That's *it*? I say, laughing. No great scene? Just *that*?

—I suspected it, she admits. I *told* you it might be that, remember? She's not saying this in the I-Told-You-So tone, so I forgive her quickly for bringing it up.

Yes, I remember, but I didn't let you finish your sentence then. I figured if you were just able to get the first syllable out, but not the rest, that it wouldn't take. Well, it took, I guess. Life—death!—is no respecter of syllables.

—You've missed something, she then says, pulling back a little. Don't pull away, Sandra. I need you to hold me closer, not pull away.

—That is?

She smiles. —Dorian Gray gave his soul to stay young. He never built anything. You've built *so much*. You still have your *soul*. You never made a deal with the Devil.

Who have you been talking to at the bar, Sandra? What's this that's come over you? A week ago, you were innocent and naïve.

No, you never were. I know that now. You never were. I saw you that way because it suited my purposes. I needed you to be that, then.

Now I'm starting to see who and who you really are. Bent and broken but hiding it well. But that's OK. I still love you. I need you to be a little deeper and more profound than I imagined you. Now that I've told you I'm dying. It makes sense. Thank you for not being as shallow as I needed you to be a week ago.

And what if I did make a deal with Satan? I don't *remember* doing it. I was probably drunk when I did. But he came calling for my soul the day we first got close. Remember when we held hands? Only, I didn't think that holding hands was enough, so I threw a drink in his face. Remember? That was Satan, come to collect. Thing is, through some strange twist of absurd fate, I ended up with *his* soul. But I don't *know* how to give it back to him. So now he's suing me. Suing me for just under seven hundred dollars for the pair of eyeglasses I ruined when I tossed that Caesar at him. Tried to sneak in something else in the claim, but I'm too smart for that. Caught that. He'll have fun with Charlie at the Courthouse trying to collect on Job 1:12.

—Those are all just metaphors, I say. Let's not talk about it anymore tonight. Just hold me.

Naked and vulnerable, the way we are *all* born. But we're not all born holding someone we love. Someone who seems to love us back. So what if that other person isn't fully in love just yet? Does it matter? As long as we can hold someone we *care* for, what does it matter? It still *means* something just for being whatever it is, doesn't it?

She's so close again.

But she's brought up a good point.

I don't *remember* making a "deal" as such with Satan. Why did he come calling for my soul that day if my soul wasn't his to come for? Then again, maybe it was his without a deal having to be struck. Maybe I was damned *per se*? Maybe the deal was signed not in blood, but in action? Maybe what I did to Anne during the divorce. No, that wasn't pleasant, but it was to the letter. Charlie made sure it was to the letter, so it couldn't be overturned later. Don't get me thinking on this stuff again. Just hold Sandra and forget it. For now. For a while.

What time is it? *Three*? Who cares?

Sandra reaches around and grabs my ass. She pulls me closer. I'm

glad she doesn't seem to care that I'm going to die. Is that sick of me? To be glad that she isn't playing violins for me? She was ready for that news. She could tell. All those drinks she's served me. All that pain she witnessed. She was ready for it. Was I as ready as she is? She wants to make love again. So do I. We walk back to the bedroom, hand in hand, and forget about this morbid balcony scene.

* * *

Phone. Go away. Reach over. Sandra doesn't stir.

—Yeah?

Charlie. Go away. Something about court date. —So soon? You got it moved to the Courthouse, then?

No more small claims nonsense. This is going all the way, Satan. Get behind me, get in line, pick a number. I built that Courthouse. I can take you on there.

—Give yourself a pat on the back, Charlie, and bill me for however long you want to take doing that. Back to sleep. The good sleep of the good.

* * *

Bacon and eggs. *That I can* wake up to and mean it. Empty bed. Well, just me here; that makes it empty. Sandra made bacon and eggs. She doesn't work today. I don't have to go in to the firm. Deborah can handle it all.

Shower. Shave. Into the kitchen. Sandra's smiling over the two plates. Thank you for not crying, Sandra. I needed that.

—Got a court date, I say. Two weeks from Monday.

Pulled a few legs and strings but got it.

She just smiles. She knows I'll win. Sure, I threw a drink in his face, ruined his glasses, but then he didn't have to go stalking me while I was pitching woo with her, did he? He's screwed.

The eggs are good. Until the phone rings again.

—Anne? I want to hang up. I should have looked at the caller ID. Is she even *allowed* to call me? I'll have to ask Charlie. Isn't there something in the settlement about this?

—Steve.

Oh, this conversation is going to go swell. Sandra is watching me. —George dump you? I can't help myself. I don't *hate* Anne anymore. Not since getting with Sandra. But I can't help myself.

—Let's not...

OK, let's not and say we didn't. You ruined my perfect breakfast, so let me ruin yours before you can get whatever it is out of your mouth. —Anne, I'm dying of brain cancer and only have a few months left to live. So this had *better* be good.

There. That's for ruining my perfect breakfast. Nothing. Just the sound of breathing. Not even a Loud What. It's about thirty seconds into this silence that I realize that there's nothing being said because I didn't actually say that to Anne. I just kept my mouth shut and *thought* it. I'm not cruel. I don't hate Anne anymore. Not since Sandra came into my life. So there's just silence. The way there should be.

—What's up, Anne? I finally do say, *almost* caring.

Wait. It's a workday. How did she *know* I would be at home instead of at the firm? When she and I were together, I was always at the firm, or at a client's site. She probably phoned me at work, and someone told her I was at home. What's going on, Anne?

—I was served a summons to appear, she says.

—What? Where?

—Nicholas vs. York.

Nick. Ha! That's great, Satan. Nick. Oh, Jesus, you have a sense of humor if nothing else, guy.

So fast? And why *you*, Anne?

—I can't afford lawyers and all that anymore, Steve. I don't know what the hell is going on here, but I don't appreciate getting served papers to appear at one of your various...

Satan, Anne. Nicholas is *Satan*. He was just trying for small claims, but I got it bumped over to the Courthouse with a counterclaim. Now

he's playing dirty by subpoenaing you. Don't you *get* it?

—Do you want to contest it? It hasn't even been determined whether or not you have any relevant testimony in this issue. Of course, you don't.

—I can't afford lawyers *anymore*, Steve. I don't want to get messed up in this.

I don't want you messed up in this either, Anne. I don't hate you *anymore*. —I'll talk to Charlie. I know you hate him, but he'll know what to do. Yes, he knows what to do, eh, Anne?

—I don't want one of *your* lawyers! Of course not.

—Your lawyer, Anne. We'll figure this out. Don't worry. Charlie will let me know if it can be done. Don't worry. I have no idea what Nicholas wants from *you*. Hell, I didn't even know he *knew* about you. Of course he knows about Anne. He's Satan, after all. He knows all my dirt, and now he's getting dirty.

I hang up, call Charlie, and ask. Charlie laughs so hard I can't help but join in.—You can't *do* that, Steven.

—So then *what*? My breakfast is cold now, Charlie.
Solve this, fast.

—What a morning, I say when I get back to Sandra.

—Why did *Anne* phone?

Seems Satan served her a subpoena to appear in this whole twisted mess. How on Earth he managed that, in so little time, with such short notice, is beyond me. He was originally going for a small claim, for Christ's sake. I'm the one that escalated it on short notice, not him. Then again, maybe he's playing this one step ahead of me. Maybe I'm being taken for a sucker here. No, Charlie and I have been tight since we were kids. Before university. Before law school. I know Charlie. How on God's Green Earth did Satan get his articling student to serve papers on Anne the very morning this went up a notch? Charlie has obviously got his work cut out for him. That articling student Satan's hired is not as wet behind the ears as those original papers let on.

—Let's go to the park, I say.

—That would be great! Sandra replies as she takes the breakfast plates to the sink and Garborates the leftovers.

—Ever drive a Jag? I ask.

—*Your* Jaguar? Are you *sure*? It's just a car, Sandra. Just a car.

—Too dizzy to drive. Can you handle a manual?

She's in the bedroom finding clothes for both of us before she can answer, —Well, rusty, but I can *try*.

That's right, hurry up. We don't have much time. Let's make the best of it, Sandra. Just don't get us killed in the Jag before the day's out, and things'll be OK.

The Glass Cathedral

John spreads the rough plans in front of me.

—You got Buick to sign off on *this*? This'll *break* him.

It's perfect, John. Absolutely *perfect*.

—Well, Deborah did the convincing.

God, she's good. Better than I ever could have dreamed. —This takes the Bentatronic concept to a whole new level, John, I say. The cost will ruin them. Wonderful.

He's nodding. This is his best work. *His* Courthouse. I didn't know John had *this* in him. Gothic techno melodrama in glass.

I motion the Door Close and the Take Seat. John does.

—By now you know the news?

—Everyone does, Steven.

I never told Deborah not to tell anyone, so everyone knows now. She's not a gossip; it's not that. It's the sobriety of what she had to say. Saved me the trouble, Deborah. Thank you again.

—John, you haven't been around here for very long. But it seems that the more I pile on, the better you get. You thrive under pressure. John smiles.

—You even look the part in the suit since I brought in the code. But get Deborah to tell you what tie goes with that color, OK?

He's still smiling. Probably figures I'm going to give him a raise. I'll raise you, for sure, John. *Right* up there. Just make sure this account doesn't fly south before it ruins Lawrence Buick.

—These plans are *perfect*, John, I continue. Not so much as a bathroom door out of place. And what you did to keep Cranston and

Healy happy after you took over for Tim on those....

Tim. Shouldn't have mentioned Tim. He may be back, one day, once he figures out how to handle the stress of being married and being in a job that expects perfection and accepts no substitution. What I'm about to say to John should have been Tim's for the hearing. But he was weak-kneed when it mattered most.

—When I die ... There it goes. That makes John flustered. He looks down. — ... someone is going to have to run this place. Sign off. Be perfect, all the time, even under pressure. *Extreme* pressure. Lives are at stake if the beams aren't just right. Roofs can't be falling on human beings, John. You feel *that* in your blood. You *know* what I mean. And you're *perfect*. Just look at this cathedral we're going to build. This Bentatronic Corporation Tower of Babel, the Sky's the Limit.

—Steven, I.... Shut up.

—And Deborah's going higher, too, I add. Just you and her bring this Bentatronic account where I want it to go, and when I die, John, *this* chair is *yours*. I slap the armrest and point at him with the other hand, to make it clear.

John wasn't expecting that. Of course not. He knew I'm dying, but he wasn't expecting *that*. Everyone here knows now. But only John's been made this offer he can't refuse.

—You and Deborah are going to carry on the York legacy. My legacy. But York is only my last name. This place is *all* of you people, out there. Pointing at the door now. —It's not *me*. Not since you people brought us where we are. That's how a company grows, John. Beyond *me*. You're the two I have decided are *built* for this. Long pause. —*If* you keep this Bentatronic thing going to its natural conclusion.

How's that for pressure? Can you keep up with *that*? The Bentatronic board is already whining about cost, but we've got Larry the Shirt into this *deep* now. He signed off on these plans, didn't he? *You* can keep them, John. Keep them spending. Keep them spending that IPO money until Buick the Citroën is *dry*.

—Who's going to own York?

Oh, c'mon, John. What the hell do you think by asking that? I

can't tell you, yet. She's testifying tomorrow on my behalf and can't know until I'm dead that she gets the whole thing. If she knew, someone could claim her testimony is tainted. Yeah, not a criminal case, but can't have any appearance of impropriety. Besides, you've never met Sandra.

—My designated heir will own it all but will have no control of York. That's all you need to know. You and Deborah are going to run this place without any interference. *No worries*. The lawyers will make sure you have no worries.

—This is all coming pretty fast, Steve.

—I only just found out I'm a walking dead man, John. Not all that long ago. So it's news to all of us. What do you think I'm going to do? Leave this all to the State? I've got no kids, and the divorce is so *through*, so *done*, that Anne doesn't get a penny of this *even* when I die. She doesn't even know I'm ticking on borrowed ticks, and I don't want her to find out until she reads it in the society obits.

—Still, pretty fast. I'm honored. I'll do right by York and what it stands for. What we made it together. Thanks for your confidence.

—Make sure this Bentatronic thing carries through, and this is all yours, John. I reach over and offer the Shake. He takes my hand. I can tell he's scared, but he handles pressure well. That's why *John* and not that Tim guy who's on leave. Pressure cooker smile. Pressure cooker handshake. The John Gillman of Steel. Glass and two-by-fours and chicken wire in a few places, but steel where it *matters*.

Maybe I should *tell* Sandra what I almost told John. That it's all going to be hers. No, that would ruin it. Besides, Charlie strongly advised against her knowing. Finding out I owned the tower I live in was enough news of this kind for some time to come. Let's not ruin it yet. Charlie is working out the papers and details of all that. She doesn't need to know until it's actually hers.

John's already at the door when I say, —Oh, and make sure you consult with Deborah on the right color tie. Have the right color on tomorrow morning.

He nods. The door's almost shut when I add, —Or you're fired. His head peeks in, eyes wide open. — Pressure! Pressure! I laugh. I still

can do that, so I will. I love pulling John's chain.

Halfway down the hall, I look into Deborah's office. She's in an office now. No more front desk. —John has some news for you, I say. And a question about his tie.

I keep going, past George at the front. Why does he have to go and have the same first name as the guy Anne ran off with? I don't hate you for it, George. Only because I stopped hating Anne when Sandra came along. Lucky you. At least you won't read it in the obits.

A few minutes later, I'm at the bar, leaning over my drink. The vertigo makes driving difficult, but I can do it safely if I shut my left eye now and again. Live and learn. Die and learn. Got here by pure luck and a few freaked out pedestrians.

Sandra's all smiles, as usual. It's amazing that she can smile so much, and really *mean* it. It must be all of fifteen minutes before Larry Buick arrives with one of the other shirts. He sees me, comes over, and pulls up a drink. Not long ago, I took this idiot for someone whose boss's boss I hired. Now I just take him for an idiot.

At least he's an idiot with expensive taste in cathedrals.

—Amazing, Steve. Stop calling me that. Steven at least. Even Steven.

—I'm in total agreement, the other shirt says. Of course you are, buddy. Those plans are the house that John is going to build. On "your" money. Rather, on the IPO money you're so eager to burn on giving "your" company some *presence*. Burn, baby, burn.

—This is *exactly* where we want Bentatronic to go. Larry, Larry. That regal we. Of course it is. So do I; want it to go *there* I mean. But when are you going to clue in that no matter what building you are in, no matter where you do your business, you build a company on the people, on the product, on service, on excellence, and you don't go to the so-called next level based on *exteriors* or *interiors*. Well, the interiors of *people*, Larry, not buildings. I'm an architect, so you won't often here me say it, but buildings aren't companies, Larry. *People* are companies. People provide services. People build product. People. *People* matter, Larry. Not *presence* and *brand* and all that baffle-garbage. Buildings, even the ones built to last, are only buildings. Empty shells. Useless

trappings. Very large, very solid ... suits. Steel shirts, Larry. Nothing more. It's not often you'll hear an *architect* say *that*, Larry, but I'm giving you some free advice here, so listen up. *People* bought your public stock, buster. People *you* are willing to screw over for your *presence*.

Of course, I'm not actually giving this advice out loud, am I? To do that might break the *spell*. The *lust* you're feeling. I smile instead. Smiles compliment lust nicely. — And this is what will take Bentatronic where we want it to go. Notice the subtle us of *we* there, Larry. That's not the *regal* we *you* sometimes use when you're talking about yourself in the plural, buddy. That's the Deborah and I *we*. We are leading you by your grubby little palm through the valley of temptation, buddy, and you're going down the river to be baptized in the Fire of Pride that Goethe Before the Fall. I hear it only hurts for ... the rest of your life.

After some back slapping and the usual back and forth hype-baffle, Sandra's shift ends and she and I are gone from *The Cradle on Sixth*. He seemed a bit put off that I had to leave, but people who want to live in glass cathedrals ought to know they shouldn't throw stones, so he didn't voice his disappointment. I saw it though. *Steve*. Thinks we're buddies. No, no stone throwing if you're building *your* dreams of glory on IPO money. Lawrence Buick doesn't know that, and I want to keep things that way for now, so I'm polite with him about having to leave.

Sandra drives us to my place. She's used to the transmission now, so it's a smooth ride. Get used to this car, Sandra; it's yours soon. I know that sounds syrupy of me, but I'm not saying it, so the syrup is inside, isn't it?

★ ★ ★

What some people don't realize is that Satan could not have offered Christ the kingdoms of the world from up there on the mountain if Satan didn't already *own* them. Jesus would have said, "Not yours to offer, Satan." They don't get that. Get behind me, Satan.

You and I *never* made a deal, either, buddy. I'm no Jesus Christ, for sure. But you and I never made a deal of *any* kind. You probably figured I was too drunk and too depressed to care, in the death throes of divorce, when you came up to me that day and acted as if we had a deal going. Almost had me going for a minute, guy. You deserved the drink in the face. Own up to it. Tomorrow, in court, I'm going to make an ass of you. You're getting sloppy in your old age.

Sandra and I are together now because I acted. Because I crawled out of my black pit of self-loathing and despair and threw authority and control at the firm other people's way so I would have time for *her*. I never did that for Anne, and I regret that, but Anne and I are over now, and I don't want to repair that. Too little time. But for you to come along and try to steal the credit, Satan, for something that you didn't do, just so you could lay claim to me, to what is mine, is just ridiculous.

You didn't build the Courthouse, Satan. I did. Not just my firm. Not like with the glass cathedral. I *personally* designed every angle of that place. This was back before I had so many employees doing that stuff for me. Back when my mind was clear, and my blood a little clearer. Back when I still had it in me to do all the small details. You didn't build this tower, either, buddy. These are *my* domain, buddy. I know every board in every suite here, just like I know every board at the Courthouse. Every nail, asshole. I'm going to pull out one of those nails and put one through you tomorrow. Right in front of Judge Casparian.

This balcony is not the mountain, but if you were to come here now, I'd show all that is mine and tell you to bow down before me and make an offering. No, I wouldn't hand them over to your authority if you did that. I'd kick your groveling ass off the ledge and watch you fall, buddy. You've got a lot of nerve.

—Worried about court tomorrow?

It's Sandra. Maybe I said something to Satan out loud and she heard me out here. Come on, Sandra. —Join me a while.

I remember when we were out here naked. This is our place.

—See that building over *there*?

She looks along the line I am pointing. —Which one?

—With the green light on the second window down from the top left, I explain.

Finally, —Yes.

—That green light is in a room that has ... and I went on to explain all the dimensions of that room, the kinds of wood it had in the floors, and where the support beams were.

—You built that, too?

York builds things. To last. Steven York, Even Steven, is going to die soon, but once I'm dead, I want you to come out here, on this balcony, on the balcony of *your* building, and every time you see that green light over there in that particular building, remember that I built that place. To last.

—I'm not worried about tomorrow, I tell her. You shouldn't worry either. Just tell the truth. It's not a criminal case. Civil stuff. Restraining order on that Nicholas asshole, and a few bucks short of seven hundred on his claim. Charlie's calling in the morning to offer his lawyer one more way out. One more settlement offer, in the morning. I don't want to settle out of court, but if Charlie does that, we won't even have to appear. No worries. Charlie's good. He got every nuisance witness they tried to subpoena quashed on irrelevance to the case, and they didn't even *try* to get you or Mike quashed. Open and shut, we win within minutes and we're out of there, drinking champagne.

—I've never been in the Courthouse, she says.

—It's safe. I built it, remember? Never been in a safer place. It's nothing compared to John's glass cathedral, but it was built to serve another purpose, after all. It was built to be the place Satan takes me to court and loses it all. Not just his soul, Sandra. I stole that from him already. I'd give it back to the moron if I knew how. He's going to lose the rest tomorrow, too.

I worship you, Sandra. One day, soon, this will all be yours. Just don't forget to look over at the green lit room over there once in a while and remember me and what I built.

The Final Testimony

Today's the day I take on Satan at the Courthouse I built.

You've probably been thinking that "the Courthouse" is an earthly building, somewhere in the same city as the Tower of Babel my firm built. I'm an architect, so you're thinking that it's made out of the same kind of wood, conglomerate, and all that, that every other building I've made. I led you to believe that. You see, I snookered you, the same way I snookered Satan out of his soul after I threw the Caesar in his face. Don't get too mad at me, OK? It's an easy snooker. I *am* an architect, after all. I know the angles of a good game.

But wait, didn't I take Anne there, too, to that same Courthouse? Yes and no. I took her to the Courthouse, all right. She ran off with George Deville, admitted she abandoned me, and I took her to the Courthouse, and she lost her right to our common property. Charlie saw to it that the prenuptial agreement we had was honored to the letter. I took her to the Courthouse, all right. It's the highest court going hereabouts, after all. Anne did it to herself; I just honored that.

The Courthouse isn't a place. Nothing an architect builds is *just* a place. It's a *part* of him, you see. Every board, every piece of cement, every nail. Do you think the Temple of Jerusalem is "just a place" or that the castle that is every man's home is just a *place*? It's the people inside that make a building a home, right? Of course you don't think a building is just a *place*. You're not stupid. The Courthouse is *part* of me. That's where I go when I lay down my head on the pillow after a crappy day and face the charges brought before me for the actions of the day. That's where I bring those who screw me over and think they

can get away with it.

I know the place. I built it. I know it down to the acoustics. That's why Satan and his articling student didn't want to end up at that venue, see? They wanted this to fly by my lawyer Charlie, to get him to miss the sneaky reference to Job 1:12 that those two slipped in their small claims form, to get me to sign a check for just under seven hundred bucks, and to have me lose power over everything that's mine. That's what they wanted, but I've been sued so many times that I smelled it coming and brought it up a notch.

I actually played you *twice*. You see, I'm not the defendant in this case. Not really. Let me explain.

Yes, I'm the barfly who soaked Satan in salty Caesar. (You can't say that fast if you're drunk, so put down the drink.) He threw the table when I did that and looked so pathetic I had to take his picture. Couldn't resist. He's never had his picture taken before, so I ended up owning his soul. When he called in his six corporate clones to try to get the film off me, I exposed the film, and he was screwed. He never had a case against me, small or large. Fair's fair. Even with that crook. Even Steven.

And he and I didn't make a deal. He never had a right to come calling that afternoon. Tried to pull one over and make it sound like *he'd* made me happy with Sandra. So he could have access to my soul. Knew I was dying, figured I was sloshed, and wanted a freebie. He was probably in the district looking to do business with the likes of Lawrence Buick, saw that I was on the upswing, and tried to steal the credit for it. To get a sympathy soul. But I'm wise to cheap tricks like that. I don't owe him a damned thing for what I built. I put a lot of myself into my work. It cost me my marriage to Anne. I paid the price in *other* ways. My soul wasn't his to come calling for. Now you're starting to get it. Good.

No, this isn't about me. This is about Sandra. She's sitting up there on the witness stand, about to be asked questions by my lawyer, and then by Satan's. The articling student is out of the picture now, his boss is now working on the case since you have to pass the bar to sit in a real court and do this stuff. The articling student got it this far. Idiot. Had

a few moves, but made a few mistakes, too.

Sandra's about to be asked questions. Since I came up with the counterclaim, claiming Satan's been harassing me, the picture I later took of Satan flipping me the finger is going to come up. But don't let me give it all away. Listen yourself and try to figure it out. Don't touch that drink. You might miss what this has always *really* been about.

Judge Casparian is already annoyed. A nuisance suit like this never should have come before him, but Charlie convinced him, and given my health, got it to court quickly. Satan flipped me the bird, I caught that on film. Sure, sure, I flipped Satan off first. But what did Charlie tell me about that?

If Satan couldn't *prove* I flipped *him* off *first*, it never happened, under the law. Now, don't get me wrong; Charlie's a nice guy. I've known him since before we went to university together. Charlie is *decent*. What he did in the Anne thing, well, that was just his being the best lawyer money can buy. Charlie *doesn't* mean to be flippant when he says things like that. So, as Charlie asks Sandra, who decided to swear on the Bible, rather than take a civil oath, what she saw that day I took the picture, she's going to say, —I saw Mr. Nicholas finger us.

I got the picture. It's over there, on the board. The judge can see it. Satan's kind of embarrassed. I caught him on a bad day. He looks pretty nasty in that photo. His eyes are all green, and red, and some other color I don't know the name of. You can see the color of his eyes. That's why he's mad about the eyeglasses and wants to have them replaced. Without them, his eye color gives him away, see?

Anyway, let Sandra do the talking.

—I saw Mr. Nicholas finger us.

The witness indicates the claimant, so it goes on the record that she saw Satan finger us. See? Just like I said she would say.

—Just as he was doing that, Mr. York snapped the shot.

The witness indicates the photo entered into evidence.

—Did the claimant contact you at all that day, before this incident, Miss Abbey?

Cassandra Abbey. A name as lovely as she is.

—He came into the bar ... into *The Cradle on Sixth* ... earlier that

day.

—Where you work tending bar?

—Yes. He came in. While I was working. Tending bar.

—What did he say?

—He told Mike and me ...

That's Michael Simms, whose testimony has already been entered. The other bartender at *The Cradle*. The chicken who nearly crapped his drawers when the six clones came in looking to rip the film off me.

— ... that he was going to sue. His exact words were, "I'm going to take down that bastard in court" ... pardon ... Just say it like you heard it ... "even if it ruins me."

OK. And he did sue. But not until he gave me the finger. That's the thing, see. I'm trying to get a restraining order on him. Oh, I'll pay him his money for the glasses. But on *my terms*, not *his*. He butts right out of my life and doesn't come anywhere near anyone I know or love. He keeps away from Deborah, from John, from Tim, and especially from Sandra. Hell, I don't even want him near Anne. I don't hate her anymore. Not since Sandra.

—That's my last question.

And now it really begins. Everything to this point has been leading to the next line of questions. I've pretty much got the restraining order in the bag. The snarl in the photo makes it pretty clear that Satan wants my liver on a roasting spit. That's one nasty glare beside that finger he's giving me. Nobody would want someone with *that* mug around his worst enemy.

I brought this case to the Courthouse for a deeper reason, though. Satan would have been happy to let it slip through the small claims court. Maybe even without that sneaky reference to Job 1:12 he tried to slip past us. The one that would have given him power over everything that's mine, since he has none over me.

I brought it here so Satan's lawyer could, as he's doing now, walk up to Sandra and cross-examine her. You've been listening, haven't you? Not completely buried in your Rusty Nail?

You see, Satan's an asshole. A liar. A cheat. A deceiver. Always has been, always will be. But there are certain times when even Satan and

his crew can't lie. Take when he had Jesus up on the mountain, for instance, and he offered Jesus dominion over the kingdoms of the world. I've already explained *that*. He couldn't offer Jesus what wasn't his—temporarily or not—to offer, or Jesus would have said something like, "It ain't yours to offer me," or whatever.

So, in a court, before God, under oath, his lawyer and he are bound by certain protocol. Just like with Job. Satan had God's ear back then, and when he came calling to court, he couldn't try to pull one by God. There were certain rules. Well, in the Courthouse, it's all according to those same gentleman's rules. Sandra is under oath. She swore on the Bible to tell the *truth*. Satan and his lawyer can't use sneaky weasel-words *here*. They have to follow the rules.

And this is where what she has to say next gets really important. You already know I am going to die. Soon. Very soon. I can hardly keep my balance these days. Damned vertigo has me tipping over. My brain is rot. I should have probably died the day Satan came calling, but maybe when I scoffed his soul, I bought myself some extra time for some higher purpose. The point is that I'm going to die. The papers are already set and signed.

But I had Charlie lock them away until tomorrow. Cassandra Abbey gets *everything* after I die. She'll find out about this all tomorrow. But just like with Anne, there's a prenuptial of sorts. Well, keep listening.

—Miss Abbey, Satan's lawyer begins. My client, Mr. Nicholas, is not going to deny that he "gave the finger." It's all up there in evidence for everyone to see. My question is this ...

She nods. Here it comes.

— ... did Mr. York or you do anything just before that to provoke ...

—Your honor, Counsel is asking the witness to speculate.

Oh, Charlie, for Christ's sake, shut up! This isn't a *criminal* case. Put your baffle-gab contestations away. I grab his arm and cover my mouth, to show him I don't want him to contest this question. His eyes are glaring at me.

Judge Casparian has a look on his face like he doesn't know what

the hell is going on in his own court room. This is such a trivial case for him to be presiding over. We're wasting his time. The *court's* time. But then his eyes get a glint of light in them, like he just heard Jehovah himself say something, and he says, —I'll allow the question. But take it somewhere quick, Gary, or I'll gag you. This's already gone far enough. Hurry up, for Christ's sake.

First name basis with Satan's lawyer. Figures. They're all like that.

Charlie sits down, obviously pretty pissed that I motioned for him to shut up.

—Again, Miss Abbey, Satan's lawyer ... pardon ... "Gary" starts ... —did Mr. York or yourself do anything *just before* that to provoke my client?

—Provoke?

—His obvious response, Gary explains. Did either you or Mr. York do anything that might have provoked Mr. Nicholas?

Charlie is up on his feet no longer than half a second, ready to bark a contestation, but Judge Casparian's giving him the evil eye, which in Court Look means sit down, asshole, it's almost time for lunch recess and I'm hungry.

There we go. "Gary" has asked the million-dollar question, Sandra. Think. *Think*.

Charlie says that if Satan doesn't have proof, it didn't happen under the law. Charlie's too big on the letter of the law sometimes. Ask Anne all about that someday, after I'm dead and you two are getting along as friends. Think back to that day. You should remember it pretty well. I had on a new suit. You'd never seen me in a suit. He was glaring at us from across the street, remember? Tapping his watch like he was telling me I'd missed an appointment. I sometimes miss appointments. Ask Deborah about Cranston. We kept the account, despite that, but only because of her magic with clients when I missed appointments.

— I ...

There it is. I can see on her face that she now remembers exactly what happened. Keep your anxious ass on the chair, Charlie. Don't contest shit. Let this happen. Think, Sandra.

It's on her face. She quickly looks at me. She's trying to see into me. Past my evil left eye. Past everything. She's trying to see what I *want* her to say. The truth, Sandra. The truth. Don't you get it? Be the proof Satan needs.

We're in the Courthouse. These places aren't buildings. They *mean* something. I built this place. With my life. This is the place where I bring people who screw me. Ask Anne. This is where it all gets sorted out, Sandra. You took an oath on the Bible, Sandra. Before God.

Your testimony goes from your mouth, to Judge Casparian's ears, straight to Jehovah God. Don't you get it? If you lie so that we win this stupid, trivial case that never should have made it to this venue, that should have been a small claims thing, you get *nothing*. Well, you "get" it all right, just not from me. The papers are still locked away. Take me less than five seconds to give the orders to have them mulched. You see the claimant, Sandra? That's Satan. He's got a look on his face like he knows what I'm aiming at here.

You *can* lie about what happened. That's not what I meant about this place having rules. You have every right, every bit of free will to do exactly that. Just like Lawrence Buick had every right to not spend all that money on his cathedral corporate presence. The choice was his to go modest with the IPO money. You *can* lie. But ... well, just open your mouth, forget about what you think you see in my eyes, and do what *you* want, Sandra. Anne didn't lie. She admitted that *she* left me. That's what screwed her out of half of everything, thanks to the prenup. She told the absolute truth and *lost everything*. It's not working that way now, though. The truth means something different this time around, especially for you, Sandra. Order is yours to restore. The truth should *never* cost you your due under the Law.

—Mr. York yelled ... I have my hand on Charlie's, holding him down so he can't stand. He looks at me like I'm crazy, but *he* knows me, so he doesn't contest what's about to happen ... — ... his exact words were "So sue me!" and he, Mr. York that is, gave Mr. Nicholas the finger. That seems to me to be what provoked Mr. Nicholas.

I *win*, Satan! You're *screwed now*! Ha! I told you I built this place. I know the acoustics, asshole. You're screwed now. I glare over at him

and can see him lower his head to his chest. He *knows* it.

Oh, he'll get his petty cash for the eyeglasses. I won't get the restraining order. Never really wanted it. You can't really keep Satan off your property if he has a right to be there. Order or no. He doesn't have a right to be there, now. Order or no.

Sandra lowers her head, as if she's skewered me alive. As if she's failed me. No, no. Sandra. Take it easy. We've *won*, don't you see? Just let "Gary" go on.

—Your honor, it's clear that my client was provoked, and that there's no need for a restraining order.

The gavel is down before you can say "Redemption" and the case is out. My firm has to pay all expenses for bringing this trivial case to this venue and if I wasn't at death's door I'd likely have paid a huge fine for contemptuous waste of Casparian's time. Far more than that silly amount under seven hundred bucks. Far more. Who cares?

Charlie is completely confused. Almost resigns as my lawyer. But I tell him that there's more to the law than meets the eye, and since I'm dying anyway, he agrees, for old time's sake, to keep me as a client even if this whole case did make him look a complete ass in front of his colleagues. He'll just tell them I was not of sound mind in my last days.

Sandra is sad that she decided to tell the judge and everyone else how it *actually* went. That's OK, though. It will pass. She doesn't yet understand what exactly has been going on, but she will. She'll show up at the bar, and Charlie's firm will be waiting for her with the papers. She'll end up owning what I built. Steven York builds it to last, you see. To last. He doesn't ... well ... I'm not going to explain anything else.

Oh, I'll let you in on a bit more. Not the stuff I've said I'm not going to explain. Stuff about Satan. He gets his money, but with no attachments, riders, or hidden catches. It's the first time he's won a case, but not gotten ... well, I can't say that. That would give it away.

Let's just say that "Mr. Nicholas" gets screwed out of his job—he needs a soul for that, even the damned one he had, and well, I still don't know where I put it—and now serves burgers in a very expensive pair of glasses. If he ever gets them broken again, he's really screwed,

because he won't be able to afford a new pair. His only chance is if someone else throws something in his face, and he takes it to small claims to replace them.

Only next time, he won't have a swift articling student to try to slip Job 1:12 past some sucker. Then again, who's idiot enough to throw a drink in Old Nick's squash?